

TAB 23



Board of Education Report

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Mr. Schmerelson, Dr. Rivas - Suicide Prevention and Awareness Month (Res-002-23/24) (Waiver of Board Rule 72)

Whereas, Suicide is a serious public health problem that takes an enormous toll on families, students, employees, and communities;

Whereas, In 2017, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's Youth Risk Behavior Surveillance System (YRBSS) indicated that a large number of Los Angeles Unified School District youth reported that they considered attempting suicide (25 percent of middle school and over 13 percent of high school students) and attempted suicide (10 percent of middle school and 8 percent of high school students);

Whereas, The Los Angeles County Department of Health identified access to firearms as the second leading cause of death by suicide in the county since 2016;

Whereas, In September 2016, Governor Jerry Brown signed Assembly Bill (AB) 2246, now California Education Code 215, that took effect in 2017-18, setting a requirement for all Local Educational Agencies (LEA), including county offices of education, school districts, state special schools and charter schools that serve pupils in grades 7 to 12 to adopt a policy on pupil suicide prevention that specially addresses the needs of high-risk students;

Whereas, In July 2017, Michelle King, Superintendent of Schools, approved the implementation of the annual online Suicide Prevention and Awareness Training for all District staff;

Whereas, Ninety percent of deaths by suicide can be attributed to mental illness, mental illness is treatable, and youth suicide is a preventable public health problem;

Whereas, Suicide rates increased by 36% between the years 2000 and 2021, responsible for being the second leading cause of death for people ages 10-14 and 20-34, according to the Centers for Disease Control (CDC);

Whereas, In the first year of the Coronavirus (COVID-19) pandemic, anxiety and depression increased globally by 25%, according to the World Health Organization;

Whereas, Studies show alcohol consumption increased during the COVID-19 pandemic due to stress, availability, and boredom;

Whereas, The Centers for Disease Control identified a 13% increase in substance abuse during the COVID-19 pandemic;

Whereas, The phone number of the Suicide and Crisis Hotline has changed to 988, available 24 hours a

day, 7 days a week;

Whereas, The focus on mental health aligns with the Los Angeles Unified School District's Strategic Plan on Pillar 1B, which focuses on student happiness at their schools, and Pillar 1C, which seeks to eliminate opportunity gaps. Furthermore, this also aligns with Pillars 2A, which establishes welcoming environments, 2B, the whole-child well-being, and 2C, strong social-emotional skills;

Whereas, Factors such as discrimination, adverse childhood experiences, stigma, familial and community rejection, mental illness, social networks, and other factors that compromise life functioning may result in elevated suicide risk, particularly for vulnerable student populations;

Whereas, Children and teens spend a significant amount of their young lives in school, and the personnel who interact with them daily are in a prime position to recognize the warning signs of suicide and make the appropriate referrals for help;

Whereas, Suicide prevention involves the collective efforts of families and caregivers, the school community, mental health practitioners, local community organizations, and related professionals to reduce the incidence of suicide through education, awareness, and services;

Whereas, School personnel are instrumental in helping students and their families by identifying students at-risk and linking them to school and community mental health resources;

Whereas, Suicide prevention involves inclusive school-wide activities and programs that enhance a sense of belonging, contribute to a safe and nurturing environment, and strengthen protective factors that reduce the risk for students; and

Whereas, National Suicide Prevention Week will be observed from September 10-16, 2023, to help call public attention to the increasing incidence of suicide and to inform about suicide prevention and warning signs of suicide; now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District hereby declares September Suicide Prevention Awareness Month in the Los Angeles Unified School District; and, be it finally

Resolved, That by the adoption of this resolution, the Board encourages all students, faculty, administrators, and parents to promote a climate of positive behavior support and intervention; monitor students' emotional state and well-being; and make referrals for crisis support and mental health, as needed.